

Hidden in plain sight, flanked by innocuous shops, shaded by sedate trees, the place wears an innocent façade that masks a classroom atmosphere—kids at play. Screaming and cursing is encouraged. When the name of the game is fun, two things are guaranteed: a large crowd and a large crowd with money.

You push the glass door and the gentle murmur of the street is drowned in a wave of noise. Screams, taunts, jeers and jocular expletives fortify into a solid wall of sound that appeals to the reptilian core of the brain—bringing back the grin you had lost with the wonder years of bunking lectures and mimicking lisping professors.

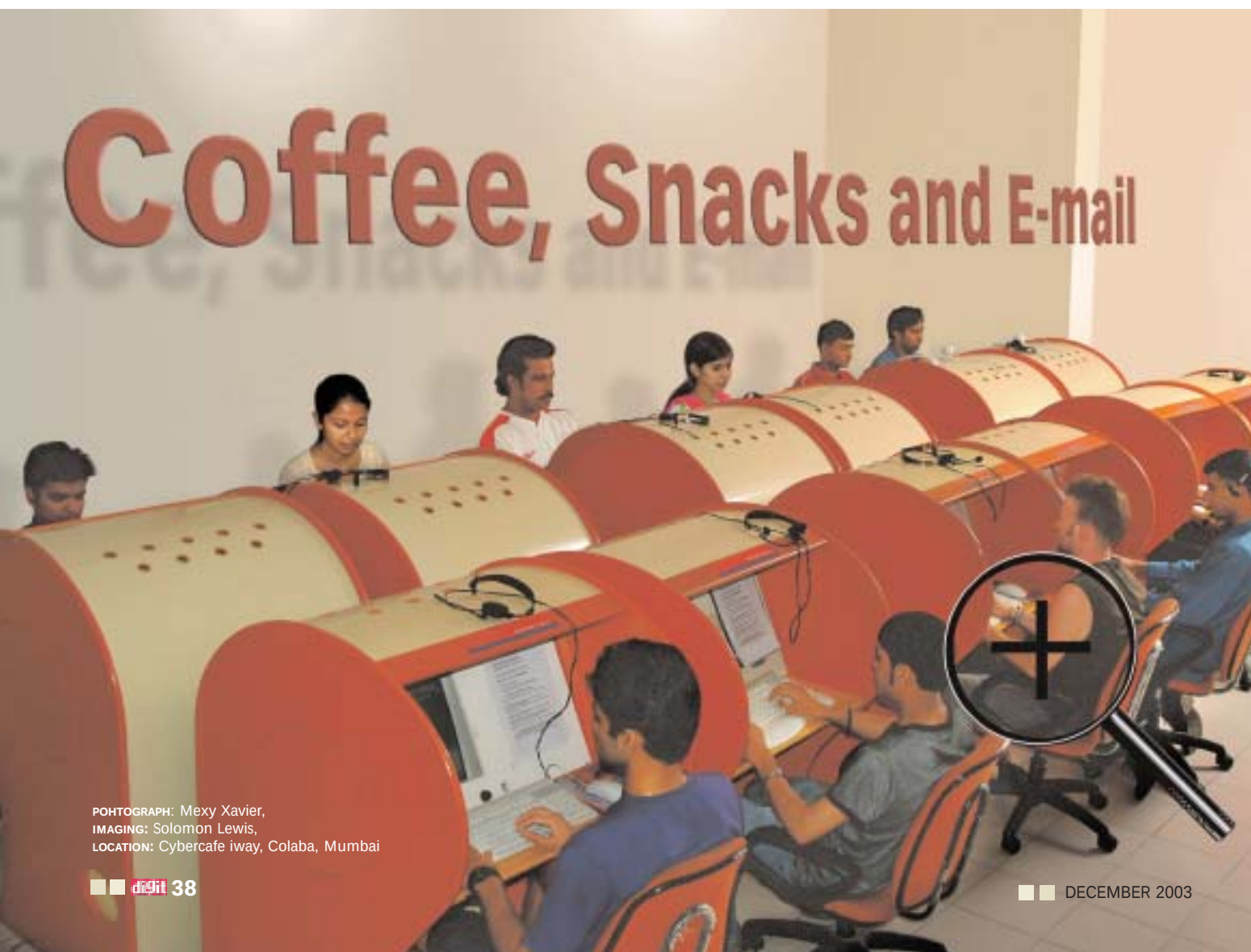
Meet Yogesh Nagdev; the crowd, the noise, the hunger for more—blame it all

on him. Well, you can't, for much like his gaming cafe, Yogesh or Yogi as he is fondly called, is imbibed with the cherubic quality of innocent fun. For him, the 450-odd square feet of real-estate—Plug In, also known in select circles as *Yogi da e-Dhaba*—heralds both money and his one true love, games. The noise gets between words, forcing repeated sentences and awkward pauses, before we find ourselves whisked to a quieter place where quotes are born. "There was a trend of cyber cafes that has disappeared. It's a difficult business now. There are cafes running near offices, schools, residential areas and commercial areas such as banks. They depend on big offices for revenue. It used to be fashionable to chat, surf, etc., but now it has become a

thing of work." So why set up a cafe? "Because I had nothing better to do (laughs). I abandoned my studies after the twelfth standard, worked at a cyber cafe for six months before I decided to start my own cyber cafe. Dad helped me a lot, the place is on rent and this is the fourth year that we are in the green and in a position to buy the place. I will do that eventually."

As Yogesh explains, cyber cafes are a different animal today. Not that they offer something unique or different—the beverage is the same, the bottle brand new. Today, cyber cafes mould themselves to their surroundings. One size does not fit all. Every owner of a successful cyber cafe will tell you a tale of those who did not make it. Thus lines are

While Baristas with WiFi access may seem an extreme proposition, cyber cafés are looking to a blend of different models to rein in and retain their customers. We stir up the brew to freshen our perspective on this social business



PHOTOGRAPH: Mexy Xavier,
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